



Photographs by ANI



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THE REGIONAL RESURGENCE
Clockwise from top left, Mamata, Uddhav, Tejaswi and Sharad Pawar with daughter Supriya Sule

construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya did not materialise. CSDS's Shastri, in fact, believes that the gains from Hindutva issues had begun "plateauing" in the state after 2019. And while Modi's polarising campaign speeches of "*mangalsutras*, *mujras* and Muslims" after the second phase may have shored up the party's core voter support, its appeal seems to have been limited since religion cannot feed empty stomachs and the young want jobs, not doles. Likewise, the BJP's poor showing in Maharashtra, where it had seized power by splitting the Shiv Sena and the Nationalist Congress Party, was evidence that not only did manufactured majorities not work, they also seriously damaged the BJP's image of being a party with a difference.

Modi's challenges may now come from within the party itself, with calls for an end to the overcentralised decision-making and what Tiwari calls the "my way or the highway" approach that has become a hallmark of the BJP under Modi.

The BJP also has reason to worry as the Congress strike rate in direct contests with it has gone up from 8 per cent in 2019 to 30 per cent now. It is being seen as a major reason why the BJP lost its majority. Election 2024 also saw the resurgence of regional forces and leaders, including Akhilesh Yadav in Uttar Pradesh, Mamata Banerjee in West Bengal, M.K. Stalin in Tamil Nadu, Sharad Pawar and Uddhav Thackeray in Maharashtra and Tejaswi Yadav in Bihar, who have consistently